

Day 4 — Modern Evidence Base for Ayurveda

Module: Ayurveda (Senior) · **Time:** 45 min

Learning objective

Students review the modern evidence base for Ayurveda, distinguishing well-evidenced interventions from poorly-evidenced ones.

Materials

- Printed abstract: Aggarwal & Harikumar (2009) on curcumin
- Printed extract: Panda (2018) on time-restricted eating
- Whiteboard

Flow

Warm-up (5 min)

Recall: Tridosha clinical vs biomedical framing distinction.

Core (25 min)

1. **Build the evidence map** on the board:

Intervention	Modern evidence	Quality
Turmeric (curcumin) — anti-inflammatory	Well-replicated; reviews in <i>Int J Biochem Cell Biol</i>	Strong
Time-restricted eating (aligned with dinacharya midday-meal principle)	Panda et al. — strong evidence for metabolic benefits	Strong
Yoga + breath for HRV	Streeter (2010), multiple studies	Moderate
Tulsi (Ocimum sanctum) adaptogenic	Modest RCT support for stress reduction	Modest
Triphala for digestive function	Some clinical evidence	Modest
Pulse diagnosis (nāḍī parīkṣā)	Inter-rater agreement studies — mixed	Weak
Specific dosha-based dietary prescriptions	Mixed; many specific claims fail RCT	Weak
Pancha-karma cleansing protocols	Limited; mostly observational	Weak

2. **The pattern.** Things that survive evidence scrutiny:

- Single-compound herbs with measurable biochemical effects (turmeric, ashwagandha, tulsi).
- Lifestyle / behavioral interventions aligned with modern lifestyle medicine (regular sleep, meal timing, exercise).
- General yoga and breath interventions.

Things that don't survive as well:

- Specific dosha-type prescriptions for unrelated conditions.
 - Mechanism claims that contradict modern physiology.
3. **The honest framing:** “Ayurveda has *some* strong evidence and *some* weak evidence. The mature stance is to use the strong, study the moderate, and be skeptical of the weak.”

Activity (10 min) — Read a real abstract

Hand out the Aggarwal & Harikumar (2009) curcumin review abstract. Students read silently. Then answer: - What conditions does it discuss curcumin for? - What's the strength of the evidence per condition? - What hedge words does the abstract use?

Wrap-up (5 min)

- Preview Day 5: “*Tomorrow — mid-module + paper topic commitment.*”

Differentiation

- **Tier up:** Read a full RCT — find one via Google Scholar on a specific Ayurvedic intervention. Critique.
- **Tier down:** Memorise the evidence-strength table.

Teacher notes

- The “evidence map” is the most important takeaway. Distinguish well-evidenced from weakly-evidenced. Don't lump.
- Some students will resist the “weak evidence” verdict on parts they personally value. Validate the value; hold the evidence standard.

Citation(s) used

- Aggarwal, B. B., & Harikumar, K. B. (2009). *Int J Biochem Cell Biol*, 41(1), 40–59.
- Panda, S. (2018). *The Circadian Code*. Rodale.
- Streeter, C. C., et al. (2010). *J Altern Complement Med*, 16(11), 1145–1152.